that agriculture be converted to focus on exports at the expense of traditional crops. This transformation benefited agro-business, undermined food security, destroyed the peasantry, and accentuated a rural exodus. Free-trade standards pushed by the WTO forced export specialisation onto many peripheral economies, converting them into net purchasers of basic products. They lost their national food reserves and found themselves unprepared to face the current cycle of rising costs. This vulnerability favoured several developed economies that subsequently offloaded their surpluses onto ruined communities who had previously been self-sufficient. Malnutrition constitutes the sharpest end of the stick when it comes to the regression suffered by the Third World as transnational corporations covet and prey on their natural resources, with oil, minerals, water and forests being the major targets for this theft.

Can Africa withstand the pressure?

Sub-Saharan Africa has been a major site for social tragedies, including the terrible dramas of refugees, mass migrations and ethnic massacres. Bloodletting generated by local wars has cost three million lives. During the 1980s and 1990s, the region suffered a decline in life expectancy from 58 years to just 51 years by 2001. This macabre scene resulted from innumerable disputes over the appropriation of natural resources. Battles between local bosses for control over exportable resources provoked the total collapse of several societies (Rwanda, Somalia, Liberia, Sierra Leone). Others were bled dry for coltan (Republic of the Congo) or by the appearance of diamonds, copper and oil (Ivory Coast, Sudan, Angola). The battle for these prizes reanimated old ethnic, regional and confessional rivalries, which were promoted by the elites and which disrupted the decolonisation process during the 1960s and 1970s.[28]

It is not the case that Africa suffered these disgraces because of its 'marginalisation from the world'. In fact, it is the most integrated and subordinated region in the whole international division of labour. Its rate of extra-regional trade as a proportion of GDP (45.6%) is very high when compared to Europe (13.8%) or the United States (13.2%). The problem stems from the historic form in which this integration has occurred. During slavery, Africa suffered a demographic calamity that dramatically reduced its population. During the colonial period (1880–1960), pillage was generalised and small farmers were forced to cultivate tropical export crops. The brief period of nationalist decolonisation (1960–75) rapidly gave way to neoliberalism, which once again drove Africa back into its position as a producer of primary materials. But the current stage includes various novelties.